

The Louisiana Purchase

Trace the ripples out from the 1803 deal that doubled the size of the country — for the new nation and for the Native peoples already living on the land.

? Historical challenge

In 1803, the United States bought a huge piece of land from France for about \$15 million — and doubled the size of the country almost overnight. What caused the deal, what happened right afterward, and what changed for years to come? Follow the ripples, and think about who was helped and who was hurt.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Louisiana Purchase Treaty (1803) — National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1803 treaty that transferred the territory to the United States.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How much land and money were involved?
- Whose signatures made the deal official?

SOURCES 2

The Louisiana Purchase — Thomas Jefferson's Monticello

SECONDARY SOURCE

Why Napoleon offered the whole territory, and how Jefferson responded.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did France decide to sell?
- What did the U.S. plan to do with the new land?

SOURCES 3

U.S. Takes Possession of Louisiana — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How the land transferred in ceremonies at New Orleans and St. Louis.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Where did the transfer ceremonies happen?
- What changed for people already living there?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

WHAT CHANGED LATER?

Four dashed rectangular boxes for notes.

WHAT HAPPENED RIGHT AFTERWARD?

Four dashed rectangular boxes for notes.

WHAT CAUSED IT?

Four dashed rectangular boxes for notes.

THE EVENT

The Louisiana Purchase

April 30, 1803

Paris, France (land west of the Mississippi River)

People / groups affected

Native American nations already living on the land (Osage, Lakota, and many others)

American farmers and settlers who moved west

Enslaved African Americans, as slavery expanded into new areas

Which result mattered most?

French, Spanish, and Creole
residents of New Orleans and the
territory

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your ripples with a partner. Which effects did you both list? Which did only one of you find?
- Did you place any effect in a different ring (immediate vs. later) than your partner? Talk about why.

4 Expand

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Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Choose the one result of the Louisiana Purchase you think mattered most. Use evidence from your ripples to explain who it helped and who it hurt.